UX CASE STUDY · WORKERS' COMPENSATION SAAS

Designing a single home for workers' comp claims

How I led the end-to-end product design of Gardiant, a claims and case management platform used by vocational counselors and Retro groups, from discovery and personas to a scalable design system, testing and developer delivery.

PRODUCT	ROLE	USERS	TOOLS
Gardiant Claims Management	Senior Product Designer & Scrum Master	VOCs & NCMs, Retro groups & TPAs	Figma, Storybook, Telerik, Material

00 OVERVIEW

The product and the problem

Gardiant is an all-in-one platform for workers' compensation professionals. It brings CAC (Washington L&I's Claim and Account Center) integration, case file management, billing and real-time claim monitoring together in one place.

600+
workers' rehabilitation firms and professionals use the platform, according to Gardiant

1–2 hrs
saved per team member each day, as reported by a vocational firm owner

3
user groups served: attorneys, VOCs & NCMs, and Retro groups & TPAs

The challenge

Workers' comp professionals were juggling homegrown tools, spreadsheets and the state CAC portal to manage complex claims. Every group felt the cost differently:

VOC & NCM FIRMS
Case notes, time tracking, billing and reports lived in separate systems. Complex fee schedules and patchwork tools caused revenue leakage and long admin hours that could not be billed.

RETRO GROUPS & TPAS
Staff checked CAC by hand for every claim. Missed deadlines and late interventions let claim costs rise across all employers in the group.

My goal

Design one secure, easy-to-use workspace where each user sees what matters to them, acts on it quickly, and never has to leave the product to find a document or update.

My role

SENIOR PRODUCT DESIGNER
Owned research, personas, journeys, ideation, wireframes, the design system, high-fidelity UI and usability testing.

SCRUM MASTER (FLEXIBLE ROLE)
Facilitated sprints, unblocked developers, shared domain knowledge and verified each release on dev and staging.

Design process

Research | Define | Ideate | Design | Test | Deliver | Iterate

I followed a human-centered, double-diamond process and repeated it after every release.

01 RESEARCH

Understanding how claims really get worked

Before designing anything, I needed to see the daily reality of counselors and claims staff: where their time goes, which tools they switch between, and what makes them anxious.

Research | Define | Ideate | Design | Test | Deliver | Iterate

Methods

USER INTERVIEWS

One-on-one sessions with VOCs, NCMs, Retro coordinators and TPA staff to walk through real cases.

FEEDBACK SESSIONS

Collected feedback on the existing product and the tools users used alongside it.

QUESTIONNAIRES

Structured surveys to measure pain points, frequency of tasks and tool usage at scale.

HEURISTIC EVALUATION

Reviewed the current experience against Nielsen's 10 usability heuristics.

Key insights

1. **CAC checking is a hidden full-time job**
   Staff opened CAC claim by claim to look for new documents, reserve changes and treatment updates. Important changes were easy to miss.

2. **Documents are scattered and hard to search**
   Medical notes, vocational reports and correspondence lived in different places. Building a case history took hours.

3. **Billing is complex and error-prone**
   Multi-tier fee schedules, billing intervals and fee caps were tracked manually, which led to underbilling and rework.

4. **Retro groups need a portfolio view**
   Retro managers think across many employers. They need early warnings for claims at risk of rising costs, not just a list of claims.

5. **Trust and compliance are non-negotiable**
   Users handle sensitive medical data, so the product had to feel secure and HIPAA-compliant at every step.

Heuristic evaluation findings

VISIBILITY OF STATUS

No clear signal when a claim changed. Users had to open each record to check.

CONSISTENCY

Tables, filters and buttons behaved differently across modules.

RECOGNITION OVER RECALL

Users had to remember claim numbers and where files were stored.

02 DEFINE

Two personas, four real users

I synthesized the research into two primary personas, VOC and Retro. Each persona is grounded in two representative users, so the team could design for real variation within each group.

VC

The Vocational Counselor

VOCs & NCMs at vocational rehabilitation firms

PERSONA 1 · VOC

GOALS

- Spend more time with injured workers, less on admin
- Bill every eligible hour accurately
- Submit reports on time and in the right format

FRUSTRATIONS

- Switching between case notes, timesheets and billing tools
- Manually applying fee schedules and fee caps
- Hunting for documents across CAC and email

User A · Field counselor
Manages a large caseload, works between visits and needs fast note-taking and time logging.

User B · Firm owner
Oversees a team, reviews billing and quality, and needs a clear view of productivity and revenue.

RM

The Retro Claims Manager

Retro groups & TPAs managing many employers

PERSONA 2 · RETRO

GOALS

- Catch high-risk claims early to control costs
- See every claim across all group members in one place
- Produce monthly and quarterly Retro reports quickly

FRUSTRATIONS

- Manually checking CAC for every claim update
- Legacy systems that only record claims, not monitor them
- Building chronologies and summaries by hand

User C · Claims coordinator
Works claims daily, needs instant alerts and quick access to medical notes and documents.

User D · Retro program lead
Manages the group portfolio and needs trends, cost summaries and member-level reports.

Problem statements

VOC: How might we help counselors turn more of their working hours into billable, well-documented client work?

Retro: How might we help Retro managers spot and act on risky claims before costs escalate?

02 DEFINE · USER JOURNEYS

Mapping the journey for each persona

I mapped the end-to-end journey for both personas to find the moments of highest pain and the biggest opportunities for the product.

VOC journey: from referral to invoice

	Referral	Case setup	Client work	Reporting	Billing
DOING	Receives a new referral	Gathers claim docs from CAC	Meets the worker, logs notes and time	Writes progress reports	Applies fee schedule, sends invoice
FEELING	Motivated	Frustrated	Rushed	Pressured	Anxious
PAIN	Re-typing claim details	Docs spread across systems	Time logged in a separate tool	Copy-pasting from notes	Fee caps tracked by hand
OPPORTUNITY	Auto-create case from CAC	AI-labelled document hub	Built-in time tracking	Report templates from notes	Fee schedules & bulk invoices

Retro journey: from new claim to resolution

	New claim	Monitoring	Risk review	Intervention	Reporting
DOING	Learns about a new member claim	Checks CAC for updates	Reviews cost and treatment trends	Contacts the employer or provider	Builds monthly Retro reports
FEELING	Uncertain	Overwhelmed	Worried	In control	Drained
PAIN	Finds out late	Manual, claim-by-claim checks	No early warning	Emails outside the system	Manual data pulls
OPPORTUNITY	Instant new-claim alerts	Real-time CAC feed	At-risk claim flags	In-app email & fax	One-click group reports

Positive Neutral Negative

03 IDEATE

From many ideas to the right ones

With clear problems defined, I ran collaborative ideation with the internal team and prioritized ideas together, keeping the user at the center of every decision.

Research | Define | **Ideate** | Design | Test | Deliver | Iterate

Techniques I used

EMPATHY MAPS

Captured what each persona says, thinks, does and feels, so the team shared one picture of the user.

DOT VOTING

The team voted on ideas to find the ones with the highest value and effort balance.

USER-CENTERED REVIEW

Every idea was checked against a persona goal or pain point before moving forward.

Wireframing

Paper sketches
Fast low-fidelity layouts to explore many directions

→

Low-fidelity
Screen structure, navigation and key flows

→

High-fidelity
Detailed paper wireframes with real content

→

Review
Feedback from team, stakeholders and end users

Prioritized concepts

CLAIM ALERTS FEED

A single feed of CAC updates such as new developments, reserve changes, provider updates and treatment alerts, filtered by what each user cares about.

SMART DOCUMENT HUB

All case documents in one place, with AI labels, key data extraction and annotations.

TIME & BILLING WORKSPACE

Built-in time tracking with fee schedules, billing intervals, fee cap tracking and bulk invoices.

RETRO GROUP DASHBOARD

Portfolio view of all employers in the group, with at-risk claim flags and monthly and quarterly report summaries.

> "Design with the people who do the work, not just for them."
>
> The principle behind every review loop with stakeholders and end users

Feedback loops

INTERNAL TEAM

Checked feasibility and technical constraints early.

STAKEHOLDERS

Aligned concepts with business goals and the product roadmap.

END USERS

Validated that the flows matched real daily work.

04 DESIGN

A design system built to scale

To keep a data-heavy product consistent and fast to build, I created a design system based on Telerik and Material Design, then customized it to fit Gardiant's brand and the needs of claims work.

Research | Define | Ideate | **Design** | Test | Deliver | Iterate

TELERIK

Robust data grids, filters, schedulers and form controls for complex claims data.

MATERIAL DESIGN

Proven foundations for layout, elevation, motion and accessibility.

CUSTOMIZATION

Brand colors, typography, density and domain-specific components.

Component-based approach

Tokens	Atoms	Molecules	Organisms	Templates
Color, type, spacing	Buttons, inputs, badges	Search, filters, alert items	Data grids, claim cards	Dashboard, case view

Built in Figma with the latest features such as variables, auto layout, component properties and variants, so one change updated every screen.

COLOR TOKENS

Navy Primary Surface Due Complete Pin Note Sticky

Semantic colors make claim status and alerts readable at a glance.

TYPE SCALE

Heading	24 / Bold
Section title	16 / Semibold
Body and table text	14 / Regular
Caption and meta	12 / Medium

CORE COMPONENTS

CASE NOTE | FILTER | $ COMPLETE | DUE 9 | OPEN

Data grid | Advanced filters | Claim card | Alert item | Document viewer | Time entry | Invoice builder

Status badge | Date picker | Modal | Tabs | Toast

From Figma to Storybook

THE SHIFT

Later in the project, as AI tools changed how we worked, I moved the design system into Storybook. Components now lived in code as the single source of truth.

THE IMPACT

Designers and developers used the same components, which reduced handover gaps, sped up building, and kept the UI consistent across releases.

04 DESIGN · SOLUTIONS

Key experiences I designed

I produced high-fidelity mockups for the core flows, each one tied back to a persona pain point.

01 · REAL-TIME CLAIM MONITORING

Problem: staff checked CAC by hand.
Solution: Gardiant pulls CAC data automatically and shows filtered alerts for new developments, reserve changes, provider updates and treatment alerts.

02 · DOCUMENT MANAGEMENT WITH AI

Problem: files were scattered.
Solution: one document hub with AI labels, key data extracts, annotations and easy copy and paste.

03 · TIME TRACKING & BILLING

Problem: billable hours were lost.
Solution: built-in time tracking with multi-tier fee schedules, billing intervals, fee cap tracking and bulk invoices.

04 · RETRO GROUP MANAGEMENT

Problem: no portfolio view.
Solution: manage Retro and non-Retro employers, get new-claim updates for all members, and analyze monthly and quarterly reports.

05 · EARLY WARNING FOR RISKY CLAIMS

Problem: costs rose before anyone noticed.
Solution: claims at risk of cost escalation are flagged early so teams can act sooner.

06 · COMMUNICATION IN ONE PLACE

Problem: emails and faxes lived outside the case.
Solution: send, receive and record emails and faxes inside Gardiant with MS Office integration.

Design principles

CLARITY
Show what changed, first.

DENSITY
Fit a lot of data without clutter.

TRUST
Secure and compliant by design.

SPEED
Fewer clicks for daily tasks.

04 DESIGN · UX & UI

Designing the case workspace

The case view is where counselors spend most of their day. I designed it so claim details, goals, tasks and notes sit on one screen, with a clear visual hierarchy for a data-heavy product.

UI patterns



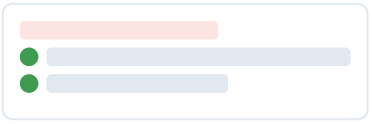
CLAIM HEADER

Claim number, dates, referral, lead counselor, status and remaining budget always stay in view.



MODULE TABS

Progress reports, claim info, documents, contacts, comms and status are one click away.

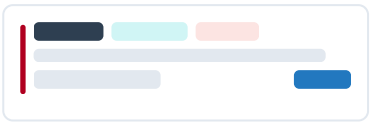


GOAL TIMELINE

Assessment goals on a vertical timeline, with red warnings for late goals and green completed states.

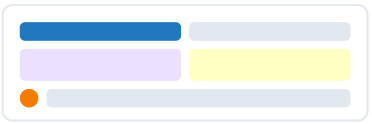
STATUS FILTERS

Submitted, drafts, due and upcoming counts with search and filters, so urgent work shows first.



TASK CARDS

Due dates in red, linked contacts and documents as chips, and a one-click complete action.



NOTES & PINNED ITEMS

Color-coded sticky notes, a rich text editor and pinned tasks keep key context beside the work.

UX decisions

THREE-COLUMN LAYOUT

Goals on the left, tasks in the center and notes on the right match how counselors scan a case from plan to action to context.

SEMANTIC COLOR

Red always means due or late, green means complete, and orange marks pinned items, so status is clear without reading.

PROGRESSIVE DISCLOSURE

Long notes are truncated with "More", and menus hold secondary actions, keeping dense screens calm.

CONSISTENT NAVIGATION

A persistent navy sidebar for global areas and blue tabs for case modules give users a stable mental map.

Accessibility & quality

CONTRAST

Status colors paired with icons and labels, never color alone.

READABLE DENSITY

Clear type scale and spacing for long working sessions.

STATES

Hover, focus, empty, loading and error states for every component.

05 TEST

Validating with real users

I tested the designs in three complementary ways, so decisions were based on evidence rather than opinion.

Research | Define | Ideate | Design | **Test** | Deliver | Iterate

METHOD	WHAT I TESTED	WHY IT MATTERED
Usability testing	Task-based sessions with VOC and Retro users, such as finding a new claim update, logging time and generating an invoice.	Revealed where users hesitated, got lost or needed extra steps.
A/B testing	Alternative layouts for the alerts feed, dashboard and key calls to action.	Let real usage decide between competing design options.
UI testing	Built screens compared against the design system on dev and staging, covering spacing, states, responsiveness and accessibility.	Kept the shipped product true to the design and consistent across modules.

What testing changed

ALERTS

Users wanted to filter alerts by type and priority, so filtering moved to the top of the feed.

NAVIGATION

Claim numbers were added to global search, so users could jump straight to a case.

BILLING

Fee cap warnings moved into the time entry flow, before the invoice step.

Examples of the kind of refinements testing produced. Replace with your own specific findings if you have them.

06 HANDOVER & DELIVERY

Beyond the design file

My work did not stop at handover. I stayed close to the development team until each feature was live and working as intended.

Research | Define | Ideate | Design | Test | **Deliver** | **Iterate**

DESIGN HANDOVER

Shared annotated specs, component documentation and interaction details through Figma and, later, Storybook.

DOMAIN KNOWLEDGE

Explained workers' comp concepts such as CAC data, fee schedules and Retro groups, so developers understood why features worked the way they did.

SCRUM MASTER

Ran sprint ceremonies, facilitated discussions and resolved developer questions quickly to keep the team moving.

RELEASE QA

Tested every release on the dev and staging platforms before it reached users.

The continuous cycle

Research → Define → Ideate → Design → Test → Develop → **Dev & Stage QA** → Release → Gather updates

After each release, I collected feedback and updates, then started the cycle again.

Outcomes

FOR USERS

One platform for claims, documents, communication and billing. A vocational firm owner reported getting back 1–2 hours a day per team member.

FOR RETRO GROUPS

A move from manual claims tracking to data-driven decisions, with CAC integration and real-time alerts helping to reduce costs.

FOR THE TEAM

A shared design system in Storybook that made building faster and kept the UI consistent.

FOR THE BUSINESS

A scalable product now used by 600+ workers' rehabilitation firms and professionals.

What I learned

In a complex domain like workers' compensation, the best designs come from deep domain understanding and close partnership with developers. Taking on the Scrum Master role taught me how to connect user needs, business goals and engineering reality, and how to keep improving the product one release at a time.

Product context and public figures are based on information published by Gardiant (gardiant.com) and its customers. All design work, research and process described are my own contributions as Senior Product Designer.